

YPRES 1914–1918: FLANDERS FIELDS & LOCAL HERITAGE

A 3-Day Immersive Battlefield Study Tour · Thursday 1st – Saturday 3rd October 2026

Base: Peace Village Hostel
Heuvelland, Belgium

THE CORE MISSION Connecting Our Village to the Memorial Walls of Flanders

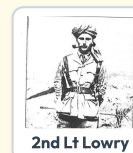
On this expedition, our pupils are not passive tourists—they are field historians carrying a profound local mission. Back home inside **Holy Rood Church, Stubbington**, carved into the marble Great War Memorial Tablet and the oak tie-beams of the village lychgate, are the names of three brothers from Manor Way Grange, Lee-on-the-Solent: **William, Cyril, and Eric Lowry**. All three gave their lives across different fronts.

"How did three sons from one coastal Hampshire family answer the call across Gallipoli, Arras, and the Somme—and how did six young men from our quiet village come to rest upon the ramparts and mud of Flanders?"

During our 3 days, pupils will physically locate and touch the carved names of our local fallen—including **Sgt. Frank Rogers** on Menin Gate Panel 35, and **Pte Muckett, Pte Rye, LCpl Ward**, and **Pte Warland** on the rear panels of Tyne Cot.



Crofton Tablet



2nd Lt Lowry



Lt Col Lowry

3-DAY FIELD EXPEDITION ITINERARY

DAY 1 THU 1 OCT

Departure, North Salient & Mine Warfare

06:15 meet at Meoncross School (06:30 coach departure) via Jet Connect executive coach to Folkestone Eurotunnel crossing. Transit to France/Belgium via Le Shuttle. Visit **Essex Farm Advanced Dressing Station** (where Lt Col John McCrae penned *"In Flanders Fields"* in May 1915 and the grave of 15-year-old Valentine Strudwick), the somber *Studentenfriedhof* at **Langemarck German Military Cemetery**, and the preserved frontline trenches and mine craters at **Hooge Crater Museum**.

Evening: Check-in at Peace Village Hostel, Heuvelland (Mesen). 2-course group dinner served on-site at our hostel accommodation.

DAY 2 FRI 2 OCT

Passchendaele Ridge, Medical Evacuation & The Menin Gate

Examine the First Gas Attack at **Vancouver Corner** (St Julien Memorial), followed by the frontline mud and preserved trenches at **Sanctuary Wood (Hill 62)**. Pilgrimage to **Tyne Cot Commonwealth Cemetery** (11,000 graves and 35,000 missing) to locate our village fallen. Supermarket lunch stop in the Salient, followed by **Lijssenthoek Military Cemetery** (major casualty clearing station & Visitors Centre) and the underground dugout experience at **Memorial Museum Passchendaele 1917** in Zonnebeke.

Evening Highlight: 2-course dinner at Peace Village, before traveling into Ypres for the solemn **8:00 PM Last Post Ceremony at the Menin Gate**, where Meoncross School pupils will lay an official wreath and locate Sgt. Frank Rogers on Panel 35.

DAY 3 SAT 3 OCT

Menin Gate Daylight, Civilian Rebirth & Poperinge Sanctuaries

Daytime study of the **Menin Gate** memorial panels and morning walk along the historic **Ypres Ramparts & Moat**. Supervised visit to **De Groote's Chocolatier** on the rebuilt Grote Markt (€30–€40 cash envelope budget). Drive to Poperinge to experience **Talbot House**—the legendary British soldiers' club where 'rank was abandoned'. Supervised lunch stop in Poperinge town centre, followed by the preserved **Town Hall Death Cells & Execution Post**. Depart for Calais Eurotunnel crossing at 14:30.

Return: Eurotunnel Le Shuttle crossing to Folkestone; approximate arrival back at Meoncross School at **20:00–20:30** (live WhatsApp updates sent en route).



Explore the Expedition on Our Digital Field Companion

We have created a bespoke digital tour companion and interactive web app for this expedition. Parents and pupils can explore the full itinerary, interactive maps, cemetery locations, local hero dossiers, and the complete 16-poem anthology from any smartphone, tablet, or home computer.

<https://meoncross-history.netlify.app> (Select 'History Battlefield Tour')



FOOTWEAR & WEATHER PROTECTION

- **Sturdy Walking Boots / Waterproof Shoes:** Essential. Broken-in with good grip. Cemetery lawns and trench duckboards are slippery when damp. No flat canvas trainers.
- **Waterproof & Windproof Coat:** Hooded rain jacket. We will be outdoors regardless of light rain.
- **Warm Fleece / Layers:** Autumn in Belgium can be chilly and breezy on exposed ridges.
- **Warm Hat & Gloves:** Mandatory for all pupils. Standing still on the stone ramparts for the 8:00 PM Menin Gate ceremony gets extremely cold.
- **Socks:** At least 4 pairs of comfortable walking socks.



LUGGAGE & DAILY BAG RULES

- **1 Main Holdall / Medium Suitcase:** Placed in coach luggage hold until arrival at hostel. Please label clearly with student's full name. Maximum 15kg.
- **1 Small Daypack (Rucksack):** Stays with student inside the coach. Must contain waterproof coat, water bottle, Day 1 packed lunch, and notebook/pen.
- **Comfortable Casual Clothes:** Practical, comfortable clothing for downtime and evening activities at the hostel (jeans, joggers, hoodies, t-shirts). No formal or restaurant clothing required.
- **Washbag & Towel:** Toothbrush, personal toiletries, roll-on deodorant only (strictly NO aerosol cans allowed on coach).



CATERING, FOOD & SPENDING MONEY

- **Day 1 (Thursday):** Pupils **MUST bring a packed lunch** and travel snacks from home for the coach journey. No fast food purchases at motorway services.
- **Days 2 & 3 Supermarket Lunches:** On both Friday and Saturday, we make supervised stops at local Belgian supermarkets where pupils choose their own fresh packed lunch items (sandwiches/rolls, fruit, drinks, snacks).
- **Included Meals & Dietary Options:** Buffet breakfasts at the hostel (Fri & Sat); 2-course evening group dinners served on-site at Peace Village (both Thu & Fri). Specific dietary requirements (e.g. vegetarian options) will be gathered alongside roomings in ~2 weeks (school already holds medical allergy records).
- **Spending Money (Euros):** Pupils require **€30 to €40 in cash (Euros)**. This comfortably covers their Friday and Saturday supermarket lunches, plus Belgian chocolates or small souvenirs.
- **Water Bottle:** Refillable water bottle for coach and field walking.



TRAVEL DOCUMENTS & DEVICES

- **Passports & GHIC/EHIC Collection:** Valid UK passports and GHIC/EHIC cards will be collected in advance by Mr Lovett at tonight's Parental Briefing meeting (or immediately afterwards) for secure administrative checks and group border clearance.
- **European 2-Pin Plug Adapter:** Required for charging mobile phones/devices in hostel bedrooms.
- **Mobile Phone Policy:** Permitted during the day for photography and accessing the history web app. To ensure all pupils receive a proper night's sleep, **all mobile phones will be collected each evening in a dedicated staff phone bag at curfew** and securely stored overnight.

Accommodation, Safety & Rooming Allocation Timeline

Expedition Base: Peace Village Hostel, Kemmelbergweg 43, 8956 Heuvelland, Belgium. A purpose-built, secure rural educational centre set in the Flemish countryside, featuring modern ensuite studios (typically 4 to 7 pupils per room with bunk beds), secure access control, and dedicated dining and recreational spaces.

Rooming Process & Dietary Options: In approximately **two weeks' time**, Mr Lovett will assemble rooming allocations in school. Pupils will be asked to nominate friends they would like to share with (ensuring every pupil is happily paired). **When this rooming information is sent out, Mr Lovett will also ask parents to confirm any specific dietary requirements (e.g. vegetarian options; note that the school already holds existing medical allergy records).** Staff sleep on the same corridors with active evening checks and a strict curfew.

PARENT ACTION ITEMS & NEXT STEPS

ITEM / ACTION	DETAILS & REQUIREMENTS	DEADLINE
Code of Conduct Form	Signed agreement by pupil & parent regarding behaviour and respect at war memorials.	Return by Fri 25 Sep
Passport & GHIC Collection	Hand in valid UK passport and GHIC/EHIC card to Mr Lovett tonight (or to School Office this week).	Tonight / This Week
Rooming & Dietary Choices	Pupils nominate friend rooming requests; parents confirm dietary options (e.g. vegetarian meals).	In Approx. 2 Weeks
Euros Currency (€)	Provide €30–€40 in cash for pupil Friday & Saturday supermarket lunches and small souvenirs.	For Departure Day

Expedition Staff: Mr B. Lovett & Mr J. Garrett (Tour Leaders) · Dr Kirkup & Mrs Lushey (Accompanying Staff)

School Base 24/7 Emergency: **+44 (0)1329 288339**